Many, if not most, geopolitical decisions are impossible to control, even by stronger powers, because there are no good options available. Look at what's happening in the European Union. Greece is about to have elections, in which it seems that Syriza, the anti-austerity party, may win. Syriza's policy is to demand a revision of the austerity measures that were imposed on Greece by a coalition of Germany, France, the International Monetary Fund, and indirectly the US Treasury. Syriza says that it does not wish to leave the euro and will not do so.

Germany says it will not be 'blackmailed' by Greece into altering its policy. Blackmailed? Little Greece can blackmail Germany? In a sense the Germans are right. Greece under Syriza would be playing hardball. The eurozone has no treaty provision either for withdrawal or for expulsion. If the strong powers try to expel Greece from the eurozone, a large number of countries may rush to withdraw for good and bad reasons.

Soon the eurozone might not exist at all, with Germany the single biggest loser. So, from Germany's (and France's) point of view, the Greek demands are a lose-lose proposition. Germany at the moment sticks to its position but has softened the threat of expulsion. France has said that it is against expulsion. This serves Syriza's objectives. That Germany in particular loses whichever stance it now chooses is one of the political consequences of chaos.

The world system is self-destructing. It is in what the scientists of complexity call a bifurcation. This means that the present system cannot survive, and that the real question is what will replace it. While we cannot predict what kind of new system will emerge, we can affect the choice between the substantive alternatives available. But we can only hope to do this by a realistic analysis of existing chaotic swings and not hide our political efforts behind delusions about reforming the existing system or by deliberate attempts to obfuscate our understanding.

In this context, what role do the BRICS play?

In 2001, Jim O'Neill, then chair of Goldman Sachs Assets Management, wrote an article for their subscribers entitled 'The world needs better economic BRICs'. O'Neill invented the acronym to describe the so-called emerging economies of Brazil, Russia, India and China, and to recommend them to investors as the economic 'future' of the world economy.

The term caught on, and the BRICs became an actual group that met together regularly and later added South Africa to membership, changing the small 's' to a capital 'S'. Since 2001, the BRICS have flourished economically, at least relative to other states in the world system. They have also become a very controversial subject. There are those who think of the BRICS as the avant-garde of anti-imperialist struggle. There are those who, quite to the contrary, think of the